

7 PRINCIPALS OF WRITING

1. Grammatically correct: Grammatical errors are an unpardonable sin! Have you ever seen a building with slanting walls jutting at odd angles instead of a straight structure supporting the edifice? Grammar, in writing, is like the straight walls that give the piece its beautiful, erect structure. Good to look at and sturdy in construction. With the basic structure gone wrong, the intention and feelings behind your words don't matter.

2. Active voice: Makes communication clear and direct. No one can forget the **“The cat ate the mouse”** and **“The mouse was eaten by the cat”** examples from our school time. Yet, we usually put the rat at the beginning of our sentence even though we are actually talking about the cat. Doing this confuses the reader and he realizes midway through the sentence what you are really talking about. Active voice, apart from making the meaning clear, also helps form less wordy sentences.

3. Concise: Nothing kills written communication like long winding sentences. William Zinsser, in his book, *On Writing Well* – which is my Bible on writing skills – talks about simplicity and clutter. He says that one needs to edit and **re-edit one's work to ruthlessly strike out every single word that does no service to your thought or language**. We do tend to use a lot of unnecessary words and have a lot of scope for making our writing more concise and clearer.

4. Structure: A clear beginning, middle, and end. Let's look at the building we mentioned earlier. How would it look if we had floors stacked haphazardly instead of neatly piled up one on top of the other? The structure is the like the floors that lead you logically to each floor of thought. And also tells you where it's leading you to. It is more challenging to

understand the chain of thought in written communication than when it is expressed verbally. Hence, it is our duty to stay on track to be able to guide our readers better.

5. Choice of words: Simple or complicated? The words that you use determine your style. Your writing could be easy on the reader or have a lot of long, hard words just for embellishment, hampering the **readers' comprehension**. What is more important is to be able to use the right words that convey the exact meaning. Words can convey positive, negative, strong, or weak messages depending on what you choose to express yourself. Hence, building your vocabulary is important.

6. Audience: The most important element of your writing! Unless you are writing your personal journal, you need to constantly keep your audience in mind. Whether you are writing for a bunch of 5 yr old or for science scholars – the style will differ. You can't treat all audience equally.

7. Punctuation: Yes, it still matters! Thanks to all forms of instant chat, we seem to have forgotten that commas and semi-colons exist for a reason. But when you communicate formally or are writing meaningful prose, you cannot afford to ignore this important principle of writing. "Let's eat, grandpa" and "let's eat grandpa" is the huge difference that punctuation can make, or the lack of it.

COMMONLY CONFUSED WORDS

Advice/Advise *Advice* is a noun: Chester gave Posey good advice. *Advise* is a verb: Chester advised Posey to avoid the questionable chicken salad.

Affect/Effect *Affect* is usually a verb: Chester's humming affected Posey's ability to concentrate. *Effect* is usually a noun: Chester was sorry for the effect his humming had. If you find yourself stumped about which one to use in a sentence, try substituting the word "alter" or "result." If "alter" fits (Chester's humming altered Posey's ability to concentrate), use *affect*. If "result" fits (Chester was sorry for the result his humming had), use *effect*.

Among/Amongst *Among* is the preferred and most common variant of this word in American English. *Amongst* is more common in British English. Neither version is wrong, but *amongst* may seem fussy to American readers.

Among/Between *Among* expresses a collective or loose relationship of several items: Chester found a letter hidden among the papers on the desk. *Between* expresses the relationship of one thing to another thing or to many other things: Posey spent all day carrying messages between Chester and the other students. The idea that *between* can be used only when talking about two things is a myth—it's perfectly correct to use *between* if you are talking about multiple binary relationships.

Assure/Ensure/Insure *Assure* means to tell someone that something will definitely happen or is definitely true: Posey assured Chester that no one would cheat at Bingo. *Ensure* means to guarantee or make sure of something: Posey took steps to ensure that no one cheated at Bingo. *Insure* means to take out an insurance policy: Posey was glad the Bingo hall was insured against damage caused by rowdy Bingo players.

Breath/Breathe *Breath* is a noun; it's the air that goes in and out of your lungs: Chester held his breath while Posey skateboarded down the stairs. *Breathe* is a verb; it means to exhale or inhale: After Posey's spectacular landing, Chester had to remind himself to breathe again.

Capital/Capitol *Capital* has several meanings. It can refer to an uppercase letter, money, or a city where a seat of government is located: Chester visited Brasília, the capital of Brazil. *Capitol* means the building where a legislature meets: Posey visited the cafe in the basement of the capitol after watching a bill become law.

Complement/Compliment A *complement* is something that completes something else. It's often used to describe things that go well together: Chester's lime green boots were a perfect complement to his jacket. A *compliment* is a nice thing to say: Posey received many compliments on her purple fedora.

Defence/Defense *Defense* is standard in American English. *Defence* is found mainly in British English.

Emigrate/Immigrate *Emigrate* means to move away from a city or country to live somewhere else: Chester's grandfather emigrated from Canada sixty years ago. *Immigrate* means to move into a country from somewhere else: Posey's sister immigrated to Ireland in 2004.

E.g./I.e. These two Latin abbreviations are often mixed up, but *e.g.* means "for example," while *i.e.* means "that is."

Empathy/Sympathy *Empathy* is the ability to understand another person's perspective or feelings. *Sympathy* is a feeling of sorrow for someone else's suffering. A *sympathizer* is someone who agrees with a particular ideal or cause.

Farther/Further *Farther* refers to physical distance: Posey can run farther than Chester. *Further* refers to metaphorical distance: Chester is further away from finishing his project than Posey is.

Gray/Grey *Gray* is the standard American English spelling. *Grey* is the standard British English spelling.

Historic/Historical *Historic* means famous, important, and influential: Chester visited the beach in Kitty Hawk where the Wright brothers made their historic first airplane flight. *Historical* means related to history: Posey donned a historical bonnet for the renaissance fair.

Imply/Infer *Imply* means to hint at something without saying it directly: Chester implied that Posey was in trouble, but he wouldn't tell her why. *Infer* means to deduce something that hasn't been stated directly: Posey inferred that Chester was nervous about something from the way he kept looking over his shoulder.

It's/Its *It's* is a **contraction** of "it is": Posey needs to pack for her trip because it's only two days away. *Its* is a possessive pronoun that means "belonging to it": Chester is obsessed with both the book and its author.

Lay/Lie *To lay* means to put or to place. One way to remember this is that there is an a in both *to lay* and *to place*: Posey will lay out her outfit before she goes to bed. *To lie* means to recline. One way to remember this is that there is an e in both *to lie* and *to recline*: Chester will lie down for a nap. Be careful, though. The past tense of *to lay* is *laid*: Posey laid out her outfit. The past tense of *to lie* is *lay*: Chester lay down for a nap over an hour ago.

Lead/Led *Lead*, when it rhymes with "bed," refers to a type of metal: Posey wore a lead apron while the dentist X-rayed her teeth. *Led* is the past tense of the verb *to lead*, which means to guide or to be first: Chester led the way.

Learned/Learnt *Learned* is standard in American English. *Learnt* is standard in British English.

Loose/Lose *Loose* is usually an adjective: Posey discovered that the cows were loose. *Lose* is always a verb. It means to misplace something or to be unvictorious in a game or contest: Chester was careful not to lose his ticket.

Principal/Principle *Principal* can be a noun or adjective. As a noun, it refers to the person in charge of a school or organization: Posey was called into the principal's office. As an adjective, it means most important: The principal reason for this meeting is to brainstorm ideas for the theme of Chester's birthday party. A *principle* (always a noun) is a firmly held belief or ideal: Posey doesn't like surprise parties as a matter of principle.

Inquiry/Enquiry *Inquiry* and *enquiry* both mean "a request for information." *Inquiry* is the standard American English spelling. *Enquiry* is the British spelling.

Stationary/Stationery *Stationary* means unmoving: The revolving door remained stationary because Posey was pushing on it the wrong way. *Stationery* refers to letter writing materials and especially to high quality paper: Chester printed his résumé on his best stationery.

Than/Then *Than* is used for comparisons: Posey runs faster than Chester. *Then* is used to indicate time or sequence: Posey took off running, and then Chester came along and finished her breakfast.

Their/There/They're *Their* is the possessive form of "they": Chester and Posey took their time. *There* indicates a place: It took them an hour to get there. *They're* is a contraction of "they are": Are Chester and Posey coming? They're almost here.

To/Too *To* is a preposition that can indicate direction: Posey walked to school. She said hello to Chester when she saw him. *To* is also used in the infinitive form of verbs: Chester waited until the last minute to do his homework. *Too* is used as an intensifier, and also means “also”: Posey waited too long to do her homework, too.

Toward/Towards *Toward* is standard in American English. *Towards* is standard in British English.

Who's/Whose *Who's* is a contraction of “who is”: Who's calling Chester at this hour? *Whose* is a possessive pronoun that means “belonging to [someone]”: Chester, whose phone hadn't stopped ringing all morning, barely ate anything for breakfast.